HELSINKI, FINLAND

Ateneum Art Museum: Masterpieces

Twenty works at the Ateneum, from Simberg's injured angel to Schjerfbeck's abbreviated faces.



An injured angel needs to be carried. A convalescent child gives attention to a small branch. These paintings place unusual or consequential subjects within precise bodily relations, allowing the image to remain understandable without closing down its meaning.

The Ateneum selection moves between Finnish literary subjects, everyday interiors and work made elsewhere in Europe and the Pacific. It also changes the amount of information a picture supplies: Schjerfbeck's late self-portrait describes a face with very few marks, while a crowded Paris garden offers many small occupations. The twenty entries follow those decisions about attention. They are one cross-section of the collection, not a complete definition of Finnish art.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/ateneum

The selection · 20

1. The Wounded Angel
   Hugo Simberg · 1903
2. Lemminkäinen's Mother
   Akseli Gallen-Kallela · 1897
3. Aino Myth, Triptych
   Akseli Gallen-Kallela · 1891
4. The Luxembourg Gardens, Paris
   Albert Edelfelt · 1887
5. The Convalescent
   Helene Schjerfbeck · 1888
6. Self-Portrait, 1912
   Helene Schjerfbeck · 1912
7. Self-Portrait, en face I
   Helene Schjerfbeck · 1945
8. Street in Auvers-sur-Oise
   Vincent van Gogh · 1890
9. The Road Bridge at L'Estaque
   Paul Cézanne · 1879–1882
10. Girl Reading
    Helene Schjerfbeck · 1904
11. The Violinist
    Pekka Halonen · 1900
12. Winter Landscape at Kinahmi
    Pekka Halonen · 1923
13. Road in Häme: A Hot Summer Day
    Werner Holmberg · 1860
14. Interior, Summer
    Elin Danielson-Gambogi · 1900–1919
15. Landscape in Tahiti: Mahana Maà
    Paul Gauguin · 1892
16. Landscape with a Pig and a Horse, Hiva Oa
    Paul Gauguin · 1903
17. Bathing Men
    Edvard Munch · 1907–1908
18. Mysterious Landscape
    Tove Jansson · c. 1930–1939
19. Spring, Study for the Jusélius Mausoleum Frescoes
    Akseli Gallen-Kallela · 1903
20. Set Design for Princess Maleine
    Nicholas Roerich · 1913

01 / 20

The Wounded Angel

Hugo Simberg

1903 · Oil on canvas · Ateneum Art Museum



Hugo Simberg. The Wounded Angel. Hugo Simberg; Finnish National Gallery; photograph: Hannu Aaltonen. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The boys can carry the angel because she has been given a body's weight and vulnerability: injured wing, bandaged eyes and a place on a stretcher. The setting is an actual location in Helsinki. These concrete relations do not settle the image's meaning. When first exhibited, it bore a dash in place of an explanatory title.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: A II 1703

02 / 20

Lemminkäinen’s Mother

Akseli Gallen-Kallela

1897 · Canvas · Ateneum Art Museum



Akseli Gallen-Kallela. Lemminkäinen's Mother. Akseli Gallen-Kallela; Finnish National Gallery; photograph: Hannu Pakarinen. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The mother remains upright beside the pale horizontal body, directing attention toward a son who cannot answer her posture. Dark water, bones and red stones give the vigil an inhospitable setting. The episode belongs to the *Kalevala*, but its immediate force depends on a relationship that can be read before the larger story is known.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: A I 640

03 / 20

Aino Myth, Triptych

Akseli Gallen-Kallela

1891 · Oil on canvas · Ateneum Art Museum



Akseli Gallen-Kallela. Aino Myth, triptych. Akseli Gallen-Kallela; Finnish National Gallery; photograph: Aleks Talve. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

Aino refuses the old sage Väinämöinen's proposal; in the central panel she escapes him again after being caught in the form of a fish. The three scenes do not make one continuous landscape. They distribute a story across separate moments, with the artist's carved frame and its *Kalevala* text helping to connect them.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: A I 518

04 / 20

The Luxembourg Gardens, Paris

Albert Edelfelt

1887 · Oil on canvas · Ateneum Art Museum



Albert Edelfelt. The Luxembourg Gardens, Paris. Albert Edelfelt; Finnish National Gallery; photograph: Hannu Pakarinen. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

A hoop, chairs and groups beneath the trees give the garden several simultaneous occupations. Playing, watching and resting remain distinct across the wide path. The public setting is made through that coexistence rather than through one commanding event. No single figure has to stand for the whole afternoon.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: A II 835

05 / 20

The Convalescent

Helene Schjerfbeck

1888 · Oil on canvas · Ateneum Art Museum



Helene Schjerfbeck. The Convalescent. Helene Schjerfbeck; Finnish National Gallery; photograph: Jenni Nurminen. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The wicker chair is large around the child, keeping physical smallness apparent even as attention returns to a branch held near the table. Recovery is represented through an ordinary object becoming worth examining. The picture does not need to reconstruct the illness; the relation between a vulnerable body and renewed interest is enough.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: A I 223

06 / 20

Self-Portrait, 1912

Helene Schjerfbeck

1912 · Canvas · Ateneum Art Museum



Helene Schjerfbeck. Self-Portrait. Helene Schjerfbeck; Finnish National Gallery; photograph: Yehia Eweis. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The face rises above a dark collar, separated from the broad grey and yellow areas behind. Different passages receive different degrees of definition, so the likeness does not pretend to be an evenly finished surface. Its economy becomes clearer beside the later frontal self-portrait, where still more descriptive information is removed.

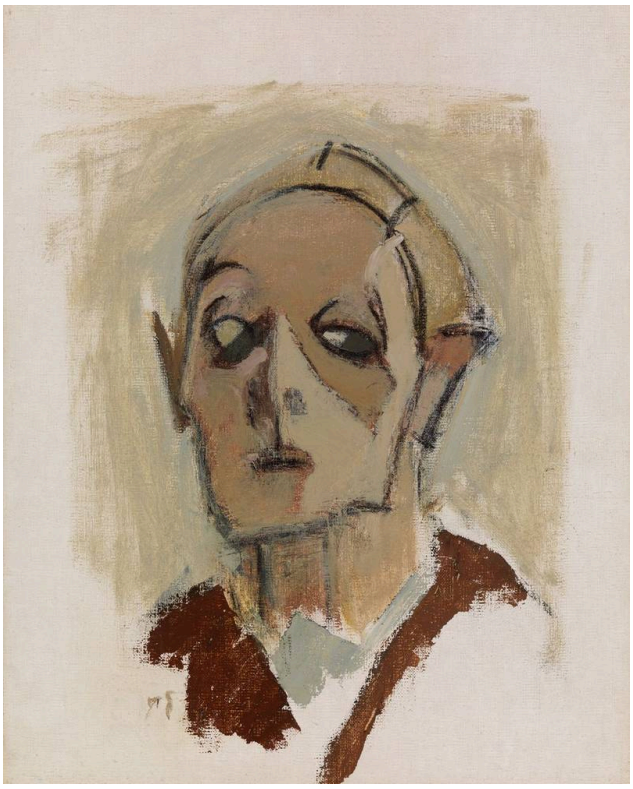
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: A-2016-51

07 / 20

Self-Portrait, en face I

Helene Schjerfbeck

1945 · Ateneum Art Museum



Helene Schjerfbeck. Self-Portrait, en face I. Helene Schjerfbeck; Finnish National Gallery; photograph: Hannu Pakarinen. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

Sparse marks give the eyes, nose and mouth just enough separation to remain legible as a face. The frontal position makes those decisions especially exposed. Comparing this with the 1912 self-portrait reveals a changed method of description, but the reduced features should not be converted into an unverified account of the artist's private thoughts.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: A-2005-131

08 / 20

Street in Auvers-sur-Oise

Vincent van Gogh

1890 · Oil on canvas · Ateneum Art Museum



Vincent van Gogh. Street in Auvers-sur-Oise. Image credit: Finnish National Gallery / Yehia Eweis. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · CC0 1.0

The road can still be followed between the houses despite the active surface around it. Roofs, vegetation and sky acquire different rhythms of mark, keeping built forms distinct from growth and atmosphere. The ordinary route through the town holds the scene together while the paint makes each part resist visual neutrality.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: A I 755

09 / 20

The Road Bridge at L’Estaque

Paul Cézanne

1879–1882 · Oil on canvas · Ateneum Art Museum



Paul Cézanne. The Road Bridge at L'Estaque. Image credit: Finnish National Gallery / Jenni Nurminen. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · CC0 1.0

The bridge gives the surrounding trees and sloping ground a firm structure to work against. Short patches of colour join into planes without entirely hiding their separateness. The landscape is therefore read in two ways at once: as a space extending inward and as adjacent painted areas that help construct that distance.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: A II 906

10 / 20

Girl Reading

Helene Schjerfbeck

1904 · Ateneum Art Museum



Helene Schjerfbeck. Girl Reading. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The chair's bars cross the girl before attention reaches her inclined profile and page. Reading is presented through absorption, with only partial access to the face. The furniture is consequential rather than incidental: its repeated divisions make the small bodily turn more visible and keep the reader within a closely organised space.

Object source · Open artwork

11 / 20

The Violinist

Pekka Halonen

1900 · Oil on canvas · Ateneum Art Museum



Pekka Halonen. The Violinist. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The violin is held through chin, hand and shoulder rather than displayed as an attribute beside the sitter. The exposed upper body makes the relation particularly direct. Musical attention has a physical arrangement here; even without hearing the instrument, the picture shows the contact and positioning on which playing depends.

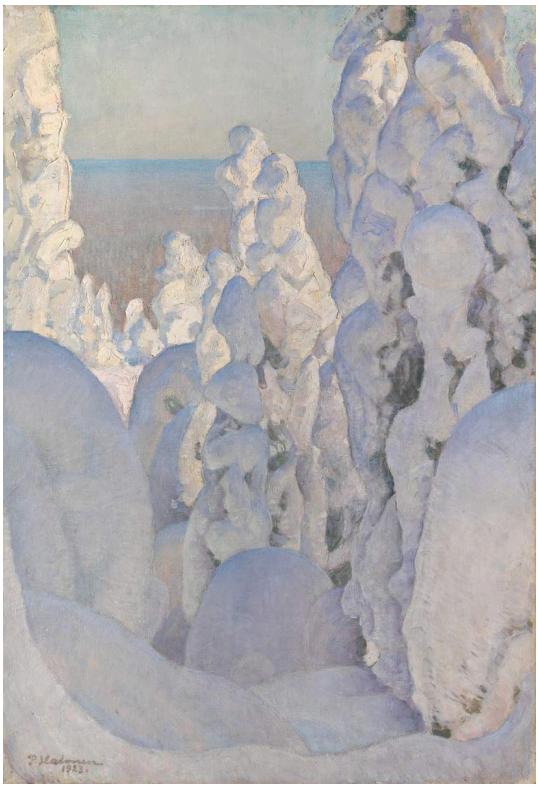
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: A III 2071

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Winter Landscape at Kinahmi

Pekka Halonen

1923 · Oil on canvas · Ateneum Art Museum



Pekka Halonen. Winter Landscape, Kinahmi, 1923. Inventory A II 1546. Pekka Halonen; Finnish National Gallery; photograph: Jenni Nurminen. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). https://kokoelma.kansallisgalleria.fi/en/object/400442. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

Snow conceals much of the trees' familiar branching, replacing it with rounded pale masses. Blue distance and internal shadows prevent those masses from merging into one unbroken white field. Winter appears as a transformation of structure: the trees remain recognisable, but the forms through which they are recognised have changed.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: A II 1546

13 / 20

Road in Häme: A Hot Summer Day

Werner Holmberg

1860 · Oil on canvas · Ateneum Art Museum



Werner Holmberg. Road in Häme (A Hot Summer Day), 1860. Inventory A II 1002. Werner Holmberg; Finnish National Gallery; photograph: Yehia Eweis. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). https://kokoelma.kansallisgalleria.fi/en/object/608901. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The small cart establishes passage along the road without taking over the forest. Patches of sun alternate with enclosure between the tall trunks, giving the journey a visible sequence. The depth is made through those changes in access and light, rather than by a single uninterrupted view of the road's destination.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: A II 1002

14 / 20

Interior, Summer

Elin Danielson-Gambogi

1900–1919 · Oil on canvas · Ateneum Art Museum



Elin Danielson-Gambogi. Interior, Summer, 1900–1919. Inventory A-2026-55. Elin Danielson-Gambogi; Finnish National Gallery; photograph: Jenni Nurminen. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). https://kokoelma.kansallisgalleria.fi/en/object/6127043. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. The current museum record dates this work 1903–1913; the existing catalogue range 1900–1919 is retained for editorial review. · CC0 1.0

The bright window and its plants give the empty room a source of activity. Light passes over pale chairs and the covered table, while warmer touches keep the furnishings from merging into one white mass. Signs of use survive without an occupant; absence does not have to become a symbolic story about who has left.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: A-2026-55

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Landscape in Tahiti: Mahana Maà

Paul Gauguin

1892 · Oil on canvas · Ateneum Art Museum



Paul Gauguin. Landscape in Tahiti (Mahana Maà). Image credit: Finnish National Gallery / Hannu Aaltonen. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · CC0 1.0

The small seated figure is surrounded by palms, buildings and emphatic orange and green areas. The colour arrangement gives the view its coherence, but should not be confused with a comprehensive account of Tahitian life. It is a selected and constructed image of a place, shaped by the painter's decisions about what receives space and emphasis.

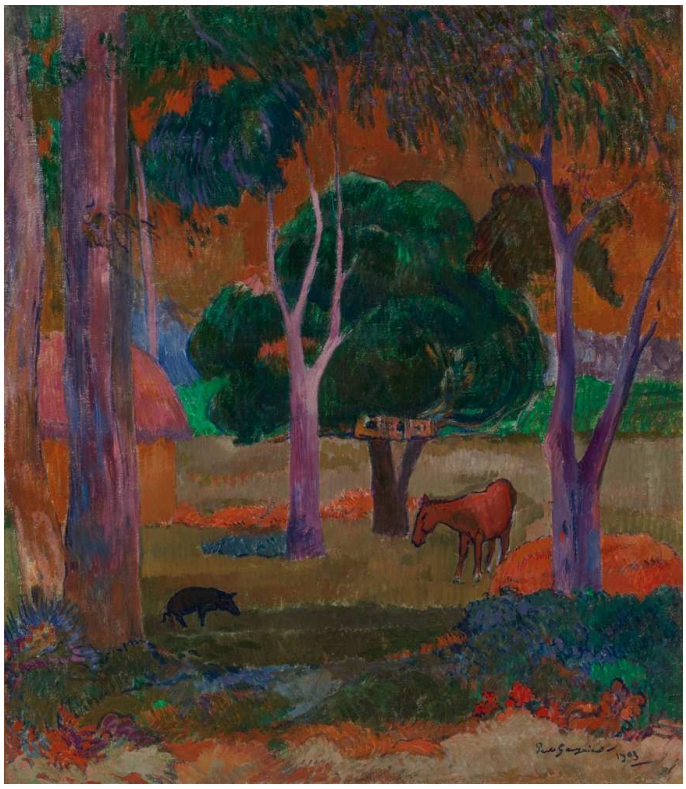
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: A II 986

16 / 20

Landscape with a Pig and a Horse, Hiva Oa

Paul Gauguin

1903 · Oil on canvas · Ateneum Art Museum



Paul Gauguin. Landscape with a Pig and a Horse (Hiva Oa). Image credit: Finnish National Gallery / Hannu Aaltonen. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · CC0 1.0

The pig and horse provide a familiar scale within a clearing surrounded by strongly coloured trunks and foliage. Purple, red and green connect the landscape without imitating a conventional palette of outdoor light. The animals remain identifiable while much of the surrounding space behaves as an enclosed pattern of colour.

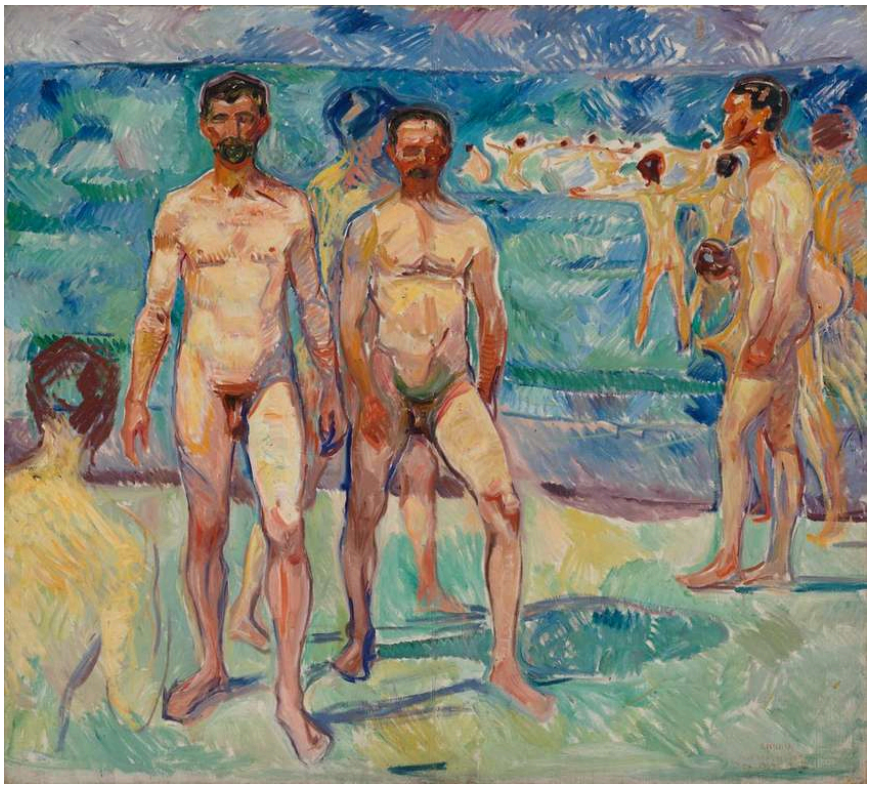
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: A II 854

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Bathing Men

Edvard Munch

1907–1908 · Oil on canvas · Ateneum Art Museum



Edvard Munch. Bathing Men ; Middle Age. Image credit: Finnish National Gallery / Aleks Talve. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · CC0 1.0

The bathers present bodies frontally and at angles, making differences of position part of the subject. Broad strokes pass across both figures and shore, connecting them to the open setting. There is no need for a separate incident to organise the group; the physical presence of several bodies already supplies a substantial comparison.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: A II 908

18 / 20

Mysterious Landscape

Tove Jansson

c. 1930–1939 · Oil on plywood · Ateneum Art Museum



Tove Jansson. Mysterious Landscape. WikiArt source label: Tove Jansson Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/tove-jansson/mysterious-landscape-1930 · Tove Jansson Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

Dark mountains and pale, drooping trees enclose a small distant opening. Paths offer possible ways through, though no specified event explains where they lead. Jansson gives the invented terrain a coherent structure without completing its story. The landscape can suggest narrative through access and obstruction alone.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: A-2006-155

19 / 20

Spring, Study for the Jusélius Mausoleum Frescoes

Akseli Gallen-Kallela

1903 · Canvas · Ateneum Art Museum



Akseli Gallen-Kallela. Spring, study for the Jusélius Mausoleum Frescoes, 1903. Inventory A IV 2962. Akseli Gallen-Kallela; Finnish National Gallery; photograph: Jenni Nurminen. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). https://kokoelma.kansallisgalleria.fi/en/object/388496. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The raised arms give growth a bodily counterpart beneath the branches. Water opens beyond the gathering, providing a broad setting for a small number of gestures. As a study for frescoes, the image also concerns how figures can organise a larger decorative space, where actions must remain legible across a wall.

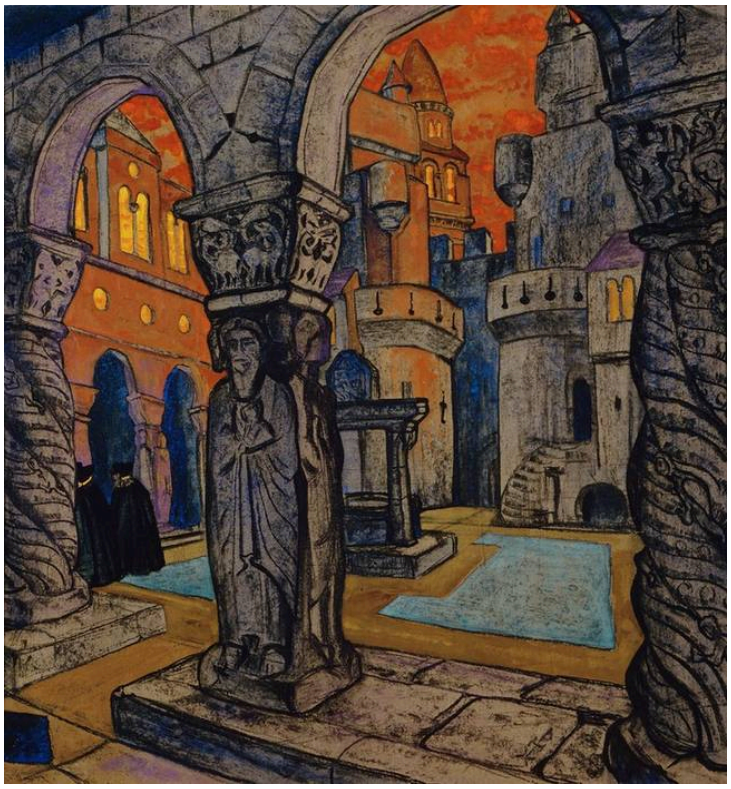
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: A IV 2962

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Set Design for Princess Maleine

Nicholas Roerich

1913 · Gouache, charcoal and pastel on paper · Ateneum Art Museum



Nicholas Roerich. Draft Set Design for Maurice Maeterlinck´s Play Princess Maleine. Image credit: Hannu Aaltonen; Finnish National Gallery / Hannu Aaltonen. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · CC0

Arches and columns create successive openings, while orange light distinguishes the space beyond. This is a proposed setting for performance rather than an architectural survey. The depth suggests where bodies might appear or pass through, allowing the design to anticipate a story without illustrating a particular instant of its action.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: A II 1267

Let the unexplained remain visible

A title or literary source can clarify an action without determining every possible reading. Return to the image after reading its story and distinguish what the picture shows from what the source supplies. For a visit, use the museum's current information; works in a collection may be on loan or off display.

Further reading

The Kalevala: The Epic Poem of Finland

Elias Lönnrot; English translation by John Martin Crawford (1888) · Free English text and ebook at Project Gutenberg.

Crawford’s nineteenth-century English translation provides the stories behind Gallen-Kallela’s Aino and Lemminkäinen paintings. Its period language is distinct from a modern translation, and the images should still be examined as the painter’s own choices.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12